people."[44] In both cases, these reassurances were aimed at preemptively refuting the accusation of antisemitism.

True, the Iranian regime uses the term "Zionist" in precisely the same way as Hitler used the term "Jew"—as the embodiment of evil. But that does not matter. True, antisemitism and anti-Zionism have gone hand in hand for ninety years beginning with Adolf Hitler's 1925 attacks on Zionism in *Mein Kampf*. But that does not matter either. The replacement of the word "Jew" with "Zionist" is obviously enough to ensure the approval of the United Nations and the silence of most Western powers.

The new Iranian Government has maintained this policy of deception. Iran's new president Hassan Rouhani has called Israel a "festering tumor" and written a book which claims that Israel is the "axis of all anti-Iranian activities."[45] Yet, he started his charm offensive with what was taken to be a bow to the Jews. In September 2013, people were thrilled by his reputed Tweet: "As the sun is about to set here in Tehran I wish all Jews, especially Iranian Jews, a blessed Rosh Hashana."[46]

His foreign minister Zarif even portrays himself as a fighter against antisemitism while simultaneously supporting Israel's destruction. In a parliamentary debate in Tehran he proclaimed that "my colleagues and I are telling the world that Iran is opposed to antisemitism and genocide."[47]

So, as we can see: The Iranian regime is not only the most antisemitic regime in the world. It is also the country that claims most loudly that it is not antisemitic but a friend of the Jews. The international community hesitates to call a spade a spade while Tehran successfully exploits the power of language.

THE MEANING OF WORDS

Does it really make such a big difference if German chancellor Angela Merkel characterizes Ahmadinejad's 2005 hate speech as "entirely unacceptable" instead of "antisemitic"?

My answer is a resounding yes. Words matter. They shape our way of thinking and determine our actions. They are able to mirror reality or to deny it. Language is key to our understanding of the world.

Whereas all kinds of things can be "unacceptable," the term "antisemitic" points to a distinctive w*eltanschauung*. Anyone who makes Jews or "Zionists" responsible for this planet's ills wants to get rid of them in order to save the world.

"The Zionist regime will be wiped out, and humanity will be liberated"—announced Mahmoud Ahmadinejad.[48] This sentiment—liberation through

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